Chavan was worried about delays in MiG deliveries and that Moscow would shortchange India on the commitment for domestic production of an advanced version of the jets.[156] Shastri admitted to Harriman that the "Soviets had not been fully coming through" and hoped to discuss the acquisition of aircraft with Johnson on a trip to the US scheduled for spring 1965.[157]

Bowles, the military attaché in India, and Deputy Assistant Secretary of Defense Peter Solbert believed that giving India the F-5s could help limit how much India turned to Moscow.[158] Harriman, too, was supportive of the Indian request.[159] Talbot argued for either giving both or neither India and Pakistan aircraft.[160] Trouble on the India-Pakistan front, however, would upend discussions of a potential US-India fighter jet deal.[161]

Pakistan: Part of the Problem or Part of the Solution?

Like its predecessor, the Johnson administration believed that India-Pakistan tension consumed Indian resources that should be directed against the China threat. An improved Indian relationship with Pakistan could result in less diversion of Indian attention and resources not just from the China front but also from development priorities that were critical to insulating India from Chinese subversion. Better India-Pakistan relations could also stymie the developing Sino-Pakistan partnership—a relationship that continued to be a major source of tension in the US-Pakistan relationship.[162]

In some ways, the US and India were not that far apart on Pakistan. For one, the Johnson administration, too, started seeing Pakistan as adding to its China problem. Rusk lamented that even as the US was "trying to stop Chinese Communist infiltration in Southeast Asia, Paks in effect seem to be encouraging them to make hay in South Asia."[163]

Second, despite Pakistani requests, most in the administration were disinclined to put too much pressure on India. Even as vice president, Johnson had been skeptical that India would heed American requests or pressure on Kashmir despite its need for the US given the looming China threat.[164] Also, the Kennedy administration's failed effort toward a Kashmir settlement had taken a toll, and policymakers felt that India and Pakistan should sort out the issue bilaterally.[165] Rusk also told Bhutto it would be the "mistake of [a] lifetime" to believe that "India can be coerced."[166] Bundy